

Herding The Cats

Building Hacker Communities in the Early Days of the Internet

Noid, NaClCON - 2026



The Internet Was Different

The Internet existed...
But it wasn't your entire life.



Balkanized Hacker Culture

BBSES

IRC

USENET

FidoNET

Local scenes



Visibility Was Dangerous

Being a well-known hacker was not considered a good thing.

	U.S. Department of Justice United States Marshals Service
WANTED	
BY U.S. MARSHALS	
NOTICE TO ARRESTING AGENCY: Before arrest, validate warrant through National Crime Information Center (NCIC).	
United States Marshals Service NCIC entry number: (NIC) <u>W721460021</u>).	
NAME:MITNICK, KEVIN DAVID	
AKS(S):MITNIK, KEVIN DAVID MERRILL, BRIAN ALLEN	
DESCRIPTION:	
Sex:	MALE
Race:	WHITE
Place of Birth:	VAN NUYS, CALIFORNIA
Date(s) of Birth:	08/06/63; 10/18/70
Height:	5'11"
Weight:	190
Eyes:	BLUE
Hair:	BROWN
Skintone:	LIGHT
Scars, Marks, Tattoos:	NONE KNOWN
Social Security Number (s):	550-39-5695
NCIC Fingerprint Classification:	DOPMCZPMI3DIPMI9PMO9
ADDRESS AND LOCALE: KNOWN TO RESIDE IN THE SAN FERNANDO VALLEY AREA OF CALIFORNIA AND LAS VEGAS, NEVADA.	

Enter LA2600

1993

A dozen weirdos

One idea:

"We should organize this"



Creating Identity

Communities need identity.



Primitive Infrastructure

USENET

IRC

Mailing Lists

Primitive Websites

[illegible]

The Discovery Problem

How do people find your community without already knowing it exists?

The image is a screenshot of the Yahoo! homepage from the year 2000. At the top, there are several icons for services: Auctions, Messenger, Check Email, the large red 'YAHOO!' logo, What's New, My Personalize, and Help. Below these are links for 'Yahoo! Mail' (free email for life), a 'Know when friends are online!' button with a smiley face icon, and a 'NEW! Y! PayDirect' button for sending/receiving money online. A search bar with a 'Search' button and a link to 'advanced search' is positioned below the mail and messenger links. A long horizontal list of navigation links follows, including Shop, Auctions, Classifieds, Shopping, Travel, Yellow Pages, Maps, Media, News, Sports, Stock Quotes, TV, Weather, Connect, Chat, Clubs, Games, GeoCities, Greetings, Mail, Members, Messenger, Personals, People Search, For Kids, Personal, My Yahoo!, Addr Book, Calendar, Briefcase, Photos, Alerts, Bookmarks, Companion, Bill Pay, and more... Below this list, the page is organized into several columns. The first column contains 'Yahoo! Shopping' (Thousands of stores. Millions of products.) with sub-sections for Departments (Apparel, Luxury, Computers, Electronics), Stores (Eddie Bauer, Gap, Macys, Victoria's Secret), and Features (Back to School, Custom coffee, Gift ideas, Yahoo! Wallet). The second column lists various categories: Arts & Humanities, Business & Economy, Computers & Internet, Education, Entertainment, Government, Health, News & Media, Recreation & Sports, Reference, Regional, Science, Social Science, and Society & Culture. The third column features 'In the News' with headlines about Bush, fuel protests, and a shuttle crew, followed by a 'Marketplace' section with links to auctions, PayDirect, and internet access, and 'Broadcast Events' including Arsenal vs. Sparta Prague and Indiana vs. Red Sox. The fourth column has 'Inside Yahoo!' with links to Yahoo!igans, Radio, Fantasy Football, and College Pick'em. At the bottom, there is a 'Local Yahoo!' section listing regional sites for Europe, Asia Pacific, Americas, and U.S. Cities.

Yahoo! Mail
free email for life

YAHOO!

What's New **My Personalize** **Help**

NEW! Y! PayDirect
send/receive money online

Search [advanced search](#)

Shop · [Auctions](#) · [Classifieds](#) · [Shopping](#) · [Travel](#) · [Yellow Pgs](#) · [Maps](#) · [Media](#) · [News](#) · [Sports](#) · [Stock Quotes](#) · [TV](#) · [Weather](#)
Connect · [Chat](#) · [Clubs](#) · [Games](#) · [GeoCities](#) · [Greetings](#) · [Mail](#) · [Members](#) · [Messenger](#) · [Personals](#) · [People Search](#) · [For Kids](#)
Personal · [My Yahoo!](#) · [Addr Book](#) · [Calendar](#) · [Briefcase](#) · [Photos](#) · [Alerts](#) · [Bookmarks](#) · [Companion](#) · [Bill Pay](#) · [more...](#)

Yahoo! Shopping - Thousands of stores. Millions of products.

Departments	Stores	Features
Apparel	Eddie Bauer	Back to School
Luxury	Gap	Custom coffee
Computers	Macys	Gift ideas
Electronics	Victoria's Secret	Yahoo! Wallet

Arts & Humanities
[Literature, Photography...](#)

Business & Economy
[B2B, Finance, Shopping, Jobs...](#)

Computers & Internet
[Internet, W/W, Software, Games...](#)

Education
[College and University, K-12...](#)

Entertainment
[Cool Links, Movies, Humor, Music...](#)

Government
[Elections, Military, Law, Taxes...](#)

Health
[Medicine, Diseases, Drugs, Fitness...](#)

News & Media
[Full Coverage, Newspapers, TV...](#)

Recreation & Sports
[Sports, Travel, Autos, Outdoors...](#)

Reference
[Libraries, Dictionaries, Quotations...](#)

Regional
[Countries, Regions, US States...](#)

Science
[Animals, Astronomy, Engineering...](#)

Social Science
[Archaeology, Economics, Languages...](#)

Society & Culture
[People, Environment, Religion...](#)

In the News

- [Bush responds to subliminal ad allegations](#)
- [Fuel protests spread in Europe as pumps run dry](#)
- [Shuttle crew open new section of space station](#)
- [Strawberry gets house arrest](#)
- [more...](#)

Marketplace

- [Y! Auctions - cars, coins, cards, stamps, comics, computers](#)
- [new! Yahoo! PayDirect - send and receive money online](#)
- [Free 56K Internet Access](#)

Broadcast Events

- 2:45pm ET : [Arsenal](#) vs. [Sparta Prague](#)
- 7pm : [Indiana vs. Red Sox](#)
- 9pm : [Third Eye Blind audio chat](#)
- [more...](#)

Inside Yahoo!

- [Yahoo!igans! - for kids](#)
- [Yahoo! Radio - tune in to your favorite station](#)
- [Play free Fantasy Football - Pro Pick'em - College Pick'em](#)

Local Yahoo!'s

Europe : [Denmark](#) · [France](#) · [Germany](#) · [Italy](#) · [Norway](#) · [Spain](#) · [Sweden](#) · [UK & Ireland](#)
Asia Pacific : [Asia](#) · [Australia & NZ](#) · [China](#) · [Chinese](#) · [HK](#) · [India](#) · [Japan](#) · [Korea](#) · [Singapore](#) · [Taiwan](#)
Americas : [Argentina](#) · [Brazil](#) · [Canada](#) · [Mexico](#) · [Spanish](#)
U.S. Cities : [Atlanta](#) · [Boston](#) · [Chicago](#) · [Dallas/FW](#) · [LA](#) · [NYC](#) · [SF Bay](#) · [Wash. DC](#) · [more...](#)

The Flyer Hustle

Go where the people already are.



mailing list: email majordomo@la2600.org
with 'subscribe la2600' in the message body

Critical Mass

The meeting stopped being the community.
It became where the community gathered.



Attention Changes Everything

Media

Law Enforcement

Visibility



The Real Test

What happens when the founder leaves?



Starting Over

Now do it again.
From scratch.

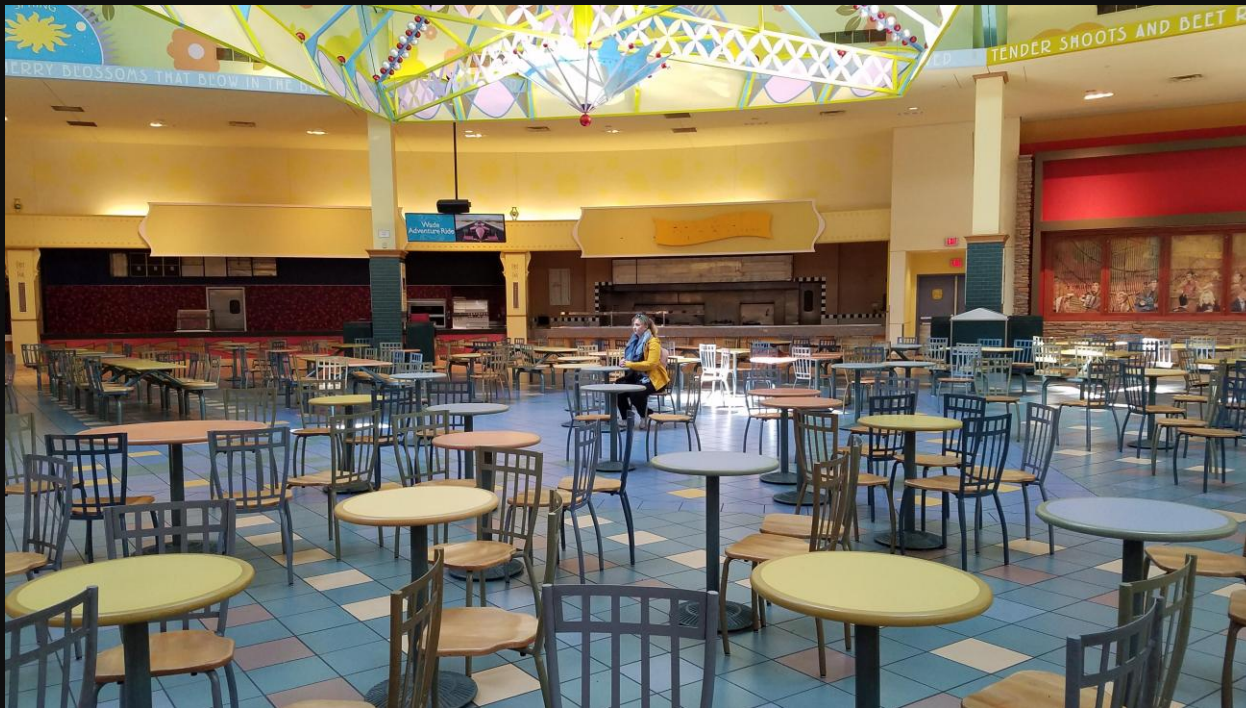


Failure

First meeting: nobody came.

Second meeting: nobody came.

Third meeting: one person showed up.



The Realization

I was trying to build a community entirely inside the online world.

Presence Matters

You have to physically show up.



Values Create Culture

We cared that you loved to hack.
That was enough.



Self-Sustaining Community

Eventually the community ran itself.



Then vs Now

Flyers vs Social Media

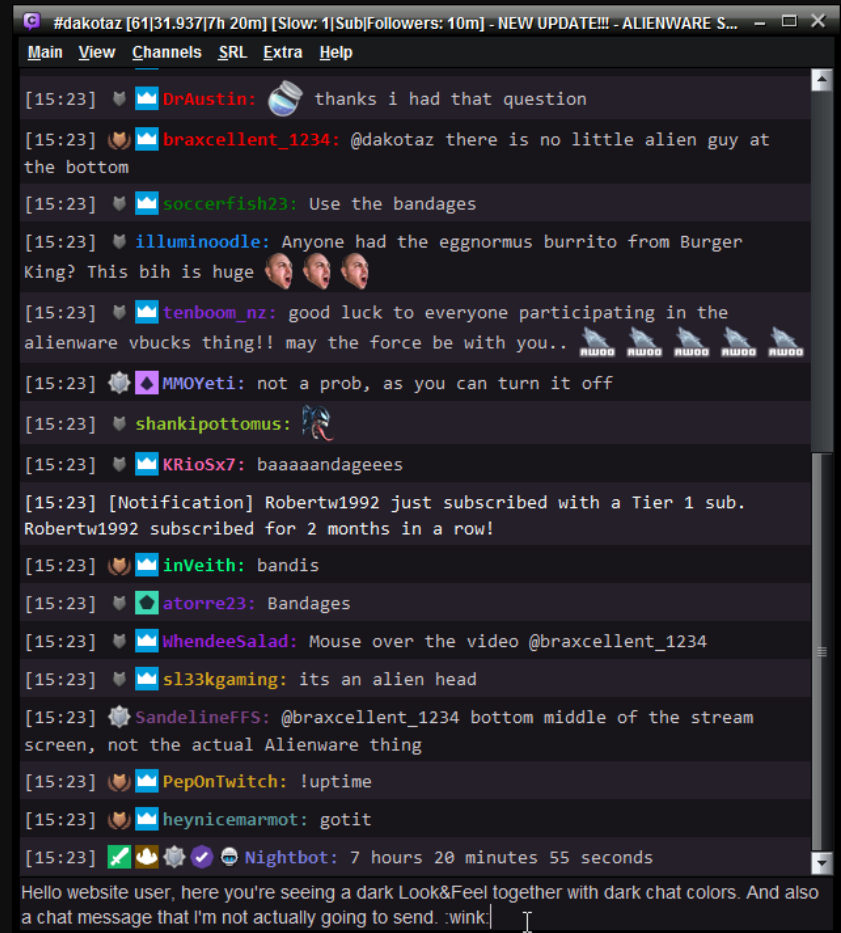
IRC vs Discord

Mailing Lists vs Slack



Easier Isn't Always Better

Modern tools solved discovery.
They did not solve loneliness.



Community vs Platform

A Discord server is not a community.
It's a tool a community may choose to use.



The Soul Problem

People used to use technology to support communities.
Now communities often exist entirely inside technology.



Building Community Still Requires the Same Things

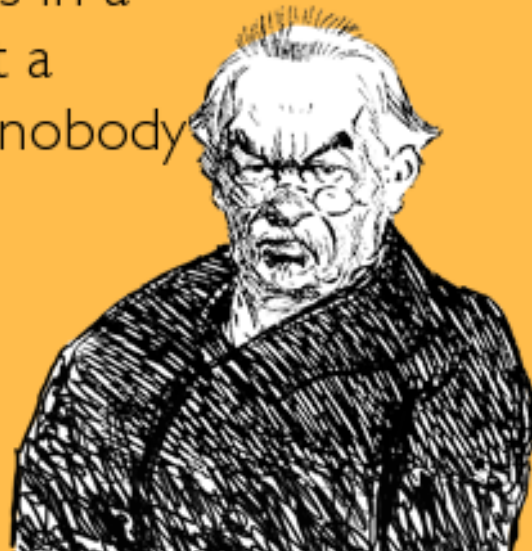
Presence
Consistency
Values
Persistence
Ritual
Leadership
Heart



Motivation Matters

Are you trying to build something meaningful...
Or are you trying to be known as the person who built it?

Doing a good job around here is like wetting your pants in a dark suit. You get a warm feeling, but nobody notices.



som^{ee}cards
user card

Final Thought

The tools changed.
Human beings didn't.

